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Chita customs officers foil the smuggling of walrus tusks to China

Chita customs officers found four walrus tusks weighing nearly 3 kg in the bag of a foreign national travelling to China through the Zabaikalsk checkpoint.

The man had wrapped the animal derivatives in clear tape, called them “wooden blocks”, and said he had bought them in the settlement of Zabaikalsk. He planned to use the raw material to make chopsticks. He also said he did not know that the goods were restricted for export, so he had not obtained the required permits or completed a passenger customs declaration.

An examination confirmed that the items were unprocessed fragments of walrus tusks. Some walrus species are listed in the Red Book of the Russian Federation. However, experts could not determine the subspecies because the material did not have enough identifying features.

Two administrative offence cases have been opened: one under Part 1 of Article 16.2 of the Code of Administrative Offences of the Russian Federation (failure to declare goods), and one under Article 16.3 (failure to comply with prohibitions and/or restrictions on the export of goods).

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